

How Israel devastated the Iranian ‘brain trust’

‘Frontline’-Post probe details June operation against nuclear scientists

BY SOUAD MEKHENNET, WARREN P. STROBEL, NILO TABRIZY AND JOHN HUDSON

Preparations for war were almost complete. Scores of trained agents working for Israel were on the ground in Iran, armed with sophisticated new weapons. Israeli air force pilots were on standby for orders to attack Iran’s nuclear infrastructure, ballistic missile launchers and air defenses. Israel and the United States, its chief backer, had argued their way to rough agreement on how close Tehran was to achieving a nuclear weapon. Diplomatic ruses were underway to blind Iran to the coming assault.

But Israeli security officials knew that to do more than fleeting damage to Iran’s sprawling nuclear program, they also had to decimate the “brain trust,” a generation of Iranian engineers and physicists who U.S. and Israeli intelligence officials believed were working on the dark arts of turning fissile nuclear material into an atomic bomb.

At about 3:21 a.m. on June 13, in the opening minutes of Israel’s 12-day war with Iran, Israeli weapons began slamming into apartment blocks and homes in the Iranian capital. Operation Narnia, the campaign against Iran’s top nuclear scientists, was underway.

Mohammad Mehdi Tehrani, a theoretical physicist and explosives expert under U.S. sanctions for his nuclear weapons work, was killed in his sixth-floor Tehran

SEE ISRAEL ON A10

Honoring the fallen



ANDREW CABALLERO-REYNOLDS/AFP/GETTY IMAGES

President Donald Trump and others pay their respects Wednesday to two Iowa National Guard members and a U.S. civilian interpreter who were killed last week in an Islamic State attack in the Syrian desert. Above, the remains of Sgt. Edgar Brian Torres-Tovar, 25, are carried at Dover Air Force Base in Delaware.

‘You see this news?’ What Kirk suspect told friends.

BY SAMUEL OAKFORD, EVAN HILL, SARAH BLASKEY AND AARON SCHAEFFER

Fifty-five minutes before he allegedly shot and killed right-wing political activist Charlie Kirk, Tyler Robinson was bragging about his success playing the online puzzle game Wordle.

It was the morning of Sept. 10. Robinson had guessed the answer — “pouty” — on his third attempt. He sent his results and a

Interactions and posts provide view into alleged killer’s life and beliefs

celebratory meme to a friend, who responded with a meme of his own and conceded that it had taken him five tries.

By then, according to prosecutors, Robinson had already driven three hours from his home in

southern Utah with a high-powered rifle. He was about to make his way onto the campus of Utah Valley University, where Kirk was set to speak to a crowd outdoors.

The quotidian exchange, ahead of the killing for which Robinson would later turn himself in, was a striking example of the compartmentalization the 22-year-old exhibited in his interactions with friends in the days before the shooting, a Washington Post examination found. And in the

years leading up to that day, friends said, Robinson betrayed no sign of passions that might suggest a capability for violence, much less murder. To many, he appeared to hold unremarkable political opinions, and he told some he was no fan of either major party.

This examination draws on interviews with 21 people who knew Robinson, as well as hundreds of messages he exchanged online over the past five years.

SEE ROBINSON ON A6

A portrait that inspired \$1 bill could fetch \$1M

BY BEN BRASCH

The image is so familiar that it often goes unnoticed: the powdered hair, the ruffled shirt, the stoic smile.

George Washington’s rendering on the \$1 bill may be the most widely distributed portrait in U.S. history. And now one of the original painted portraits that inspired the U.S. Mint’s engraving can be yours, if you have 500,000 to 1 million Washingtons to spare.

On Jan. 23 in New York, the auction house Christie’s will put up for bidding an 1804 oil portrait of Washington by Gilbert Stuart. The painting, commissioned by James Madison, has a storied history passing through the hands of the Founding Father and a gold rush tycoon.

Stuart churned out more than 100 paintings of Washington that later served as the model for the image on the dollar bill, including the piece on offer.

The image isn’t just “deeply ingrained” in the American psyche, said Carrie Rebora Barratt, who co-curated a Stuart retrospective for the Metropolitan Museum of Art in New York. It is also “the kind of magnificent story of America that collectors of American art want.”

Here are some of the key events

SEE PORTRAIT ON A4



SAUMYA KHANDELWAL/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Nabeesa Moosa’s life has been deeply affected by the Periyar river, which flows near her home in India.

Widespread use of plastic puts harmful chemicals in nearly everyone’s diet

BY SHANNON OSAKA AND NAEMA AHMED

When Americans eat a burger, they aren’t just biting through bun, lettuce, tomato and cheese. Instead, the burger — or its packaging, or the utensil used to cook it — also probably contains a blend of chemicals scientists believe harm human health. PFAS. Phthalates. BPA. Flame retardants.

These chemicals act on the body in multiple ways — confusing hormones, disrupting immune systems and boosting cancer cells. But they all have one thing in common: They are intimately linked to plastic.

Couch cushions, rugs and carpets are made of polyester fibers; furniture and flooring is coated in plastic laminates. The vast majority of food is wrapped in plastic packaging, and Ameri-

cans cook with plastic spatulas on plastic-coated pans.

Plastic ushered in a new era of convenience and filled homes with cheap, disposable goods. But it also has exposed ordinary people to tens of thousands of chemicals that slip out of those items into household dust, food, water — and from there, into bodies. Some of these chemicals are known to disrupt pregnancies, triggering birth defects and

fertility problems later in life; others have been linked to cancer and developmental problems.

The Washington Post used a comprehensive database, built by scientists in Switzerland and Norway, of 16,000 chemicals linked to plastic materials to see how people interact with chemicals in their everyday lives. Of those, scientists say, more than 5,400 chemicals are considered hazardous to human health. Re-

searchers believe that many of these chemicals are harming Americans even at typical levels of exposure.

Here’s how some of the most dangerous chemicals go from everyday items in our kitchens into our bodies.

- Many plastic chemicals are found in utensils, food packaging and cookware that come in close contact with the food we eat.

SEE PLASTIC ON A18

Bill with Hegseth penalty prevails

PRESSES RELEASE OF BOAT STRIKE VIDEO

Pentagon budget clears Senate, heads to Trump

BY NOAH ROBERTSON

The Senate on Wednesday passed Congress’s \$900 billion defense policy bill, advancing a bipartisan effort to force the Pentagon to disclose footage of a controversial military strike on an alleged drug smuggling boat near Venezuela.

The legislation advanced by a vote of 77-20. It cleared the House last week, and President Donald Trump is expected to sign it into law.

A measure in the bill withholds 25 percent of Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth’s travel budget until he provides Congress with video of the Sept. 2 operation and other materials related to the Trump administration’s unprecedented campaign against Latin American narcotics traffickers. Eleven people were killed in that attack, including two men who survived a U.S. initial strike on their vessel.

The footage is seen as essential evidence as lawmakers seek to determine whether military officials violated the law of armed conflict by targeting the boat’s wreckage with survivors present. Military law grants special protection to people who are deemed “shipwrecked,” meaning they are in peril and not engaging in hostilities. The commander who oversaw the operation has sought to defend his decision

SEE DEFENSE ON A2

In India, one dam shapes the fate of millions

Many rely on the Mullaperiyar. Many fear it, too.

BY SARAH KAPLAN, SREEKANTH SIVADASAN AND APARNA GANESAN

THEKKADY, INDIA — Deep in the mountains, shrouded by dense forests and tropical mists, the Mullaperiyar lurks like a creature from legend. Few locals have seen the massive dam that was erected here 130 years ago, plugging one of South India’s most important rivers. But nearly everyone who lives within 100 miles knows its power.

To the east, in the farmland of Tamil Nadu, the Mullaperiyar is sacred. Via a tunnel that winds beneath the surrounding mountains, the dam provides drinking water to millions of people, and its reservoir irrigates hundreds of thousands of acres of fruit

orchards and rice paddies. When seasonal rains fail, and the red soil turns cracked and dusty under a blistering sun, the dam ensures that water still flows through pipes and fills up wells.

“Mullaperiyar is my life,” said Salethu Innaci, 66, a farmer in the village of T Sindalacherry. “If someone said die for Mullaperiyar, I would.”

But to the west, in remote communities tucked among Kerala’s hills, the Mullaperiyar is a monster. When heavy monsoon rains fill the reservoir, forcing excess water to be released into the Periyar river, these areas often flood. Locals live in terror that the century-old structure — built without advanced engineering techniques or modern

SEE INDIA ON A12

IN THE NEWS

Battle over health care subsidies The Senate already rejected a plan to extend them, but a vote forced by House GOP moderates signaled rising tensions within the party. A3

New leader for D.C. police Jeffery Carroll, the department’s second-in-command, will become interim chief, Mayor Bowser said. B13

THE NATION **The EPA paid** employees on leave \$86.5 million not to work for months, data shows. A3

Partisanship is a fair consideration in cutting blue state grants, federal lawyers argue. A4

THE WORLD **Funerals began** for victims of Sydney’s mass killing as the suspect faced charges. A8

Over 30 oil tankers in the Caribbean could be affected by Trump’s Venezuela blockade. A11

THE ECONOMY **Markets data** indicates a “jobs recession” is coming to tech, as the industry’s jobless rate steadily rises. A14

This was supposed to be a year many bought a car, but high prices and interest rates as well as tariff uncertainty kept customers away. A14

STYLE **Rob and Michele** Reiner long tried to free their son Nick, the suspect in their killing, of his substance abuse. B1

SPORTS **The Commanders** season has been a disappointment, but the final stretch is crucial for a handful of players. B7

THE REGION **What started** as a month-long stay became a “nightmare” for an Airbnb host in the District who ended up in court. B13

LOCAL LIVING **Learn about** cross-stitching’s extraordinary benefits — and its history of protest.

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